

Common starfish

Along with sea cucumbers and urchins, the common starfish belongs to a group of animals called echinoderms, which live only in the ocean. Like many marine animals commonly spotted on or near the seashore, the starfish actually spends most of its life in deeper waters, as it needs to be underwater to spawn.

Many tiny feet

Like other echinoderms, starfish move from place to place using tiny sucker-like tube feet. The underside of their arms is covered in hundreds of these feet, which bend from side to side to push the animal slowly along the seafloor.

Norwegian fjords

Norway's long coastline is carved by narrow, deep inlets called fjords. The muddy and sandy bottoms of these coastal habitats are full of common starfish.

Northern delights

Even along the Kola Peninsula, above the Arctic Circle, warm currents keep waters ice-free. Here, starfish feed on the plentiful scallop-beds.

Iceland

Faroe Islands

North Sea

Rockall Banks

Kola Peninsula

Colors

The skin of the common starfish is usually orange, but some are in shades of brown or purple.

North Sea water

The North Sea is slightly less salty than the open ocean because many rivers flow into it. Common starfish still thrive here, even in river estuaries.

The Baltic Sea

The common starfish is one of the few echinoderms that can survive in the very low salt levels of the Baltic.

Mussels on the menu

The common starfish preys on lots of different invertebrates, but has a special liking for two-shelled mollusks, such as mussels. They pull the shells apart with their arms, then stick their extendable stomach through the opening to digest the meat inside.

KEY

Common starfish range

